TOPIC 3

Instructional Planning: Foundations, Levels & the Daily Lesson Plan

Methods of Teaching – Foundational Concepts

Learning Objectives

By the end of this study guide, you should be able to:

- Define instructional planning and explain why it is essential to effective teaching.
- Describe the four organizing categories of the InTASC Model Core Teaching Standards.
- Identify the major subject-specific standards frameworks for IT, Science, Mathematics, and Art & Design.
- Identify the levels of planning, from yearly/course plans down to daily lesson plans, and distinguish long-range from short-range planning.
- List common resources teachers use when planning instruction.
- Describe the essential components of a written lesson plan and their purpose.
- Explain how planning differs across the cognitive, affective, and psychomotor domains.

> **Builds on Topic 2:** Writing ABCD objectives, choosing measurable verbs, making objectives measurable and achievable, backward design, and aligning objectives with activities and assessment are covered in Topic 2 and are not repeated here.

Part A: Foundations of Instructional Planning

1. What Is Instructional Planning?

Instructional planning is the process by which a teacher decides, in advance, what students should learn, how that learning will be organized and delivered, and how it will be assessed. A plan translates broad goals (a curriculum standard, a unit theme) into concrete decisions about content, sequencing, activities, materials, grouping, and time. Planning happens at several levels, from a whole-year overview down to a single lesson (see Part B), but at every level its purpose is the same: to make teaching purposeful and coherent rather than improvised.

2. Why Planning Matters

- **Curriculum coverage** – a plan helps a teacher pace content so that all required standards are addressed within the available time.
- **Anticipation** – planning allows a teacher to foresee likely student difficulties, prepare materials, and think through classroom-management issues before they occur.

- **Differentiation** – advance planning creates room to design alternative tasks or supports for learners with different needs.
- **Coherence** – planning keeps the parts of a lesson connected to one another and to the larger unit, rather than a list of separate activities.
- **Professional accountability** – clear plans make a teacher's instructional decisions visible and defensible to supervisors, colleagues, and families.

3. The InTASC Model Core Teaching Standards

The Interstate Teacher Assessment and Support Consortium (InTASC), coordinated by the Council of Chief State School Officers (CCSSO, 2013), publishes a widely adopted set of ten standards describing what effective teachers should know and be able to do. Originally written for beginning teachers, the standards were revised in 2011 to apply to teachers at every stage of their careers. The ten standards are grouped into four categories.

Key Framework: InTASC Model Core Teaching Standards (CCSSO, 2013)

Category	Standards	Focus
The Learner and Learning	1–3	Learner development, learning differences, and creating a supportive learning environment.
Content	4–5	Deep content knowledge and the ability to apply it, connecting concepts and perspectives to engage learners in critical thinking and problem solving.
Instructional Practice	6–8	Assessment, planning for instruction, and using varied instructional strategies.
Professional Responsibility	9–10	Professional learning and ethical practice; leadership and collaboration with colleagues, families, and the community.

These categories give teachers a shared professional language that recurs throughout this course: planning (this topic), instructional strategies, and assessment all belong to the Instructional Practice category.

4. Subject-Specific Standards Frameworks

Each discipline also has its own standards framework. These are the main frameworks for the four specializations in this course:

Specialization	Framework	Main Emphasis
IT	ISTE Standards (International Society for Technology in Education)	The Standards for Educators guide the effective use of digital tools in teaching; the Standards for Students describe learner roles (e.g., *Computational Thinker*) that educators plan toward.
Mathematics	NCTM Principles and Standards for School Mathematics	Content standards plus five process standards: problem solving, reasoning and proof, communication, connections, and representation.
Science	National Science Education Standards (NSES) / Next Generation Science Standards (NGSS)	Science content expectations; the NSES emphasized inquiry, which the NGSS frames as science and engineering practices (e.g., asking questions, planning and carrying out investigations).
Art & Design	National Core Arts Standards	Four artistic processes: Creating; Performing/Presenting/Producing; Responding; and Connecting.

Part B: Levels and Types of Planning

5. Levels of Planning

Instructional planning is organized into a hierarchy that moves from broad and long-term to specific and immediate (Burden & Byrd, 2019). Each level works within the limits set by the broader level before it and narrows the focus.

Key Framework: The Planning Hierarchy

Level	Time Span	Purpose
Yearly / Course Plan	One academic year or course	Maps major units and standards across the entire course; ensures full curriculum coverage.
Term Plan	One semester or term	Divides the yearly plan into the units and topics to be completed within a single term.
Unit Plan	Several weeks	Organizes a coherent block of related lessons around a shared theme, concept, or set of standards.
Weekly Plan	One week	Distributes the unit's lessons across the days of the week and schedules activities, assessments, and materials.
Daily Lesson Plan	One class session	Details the objectives, activities, timing of each step, and assessment for a single teaching period.

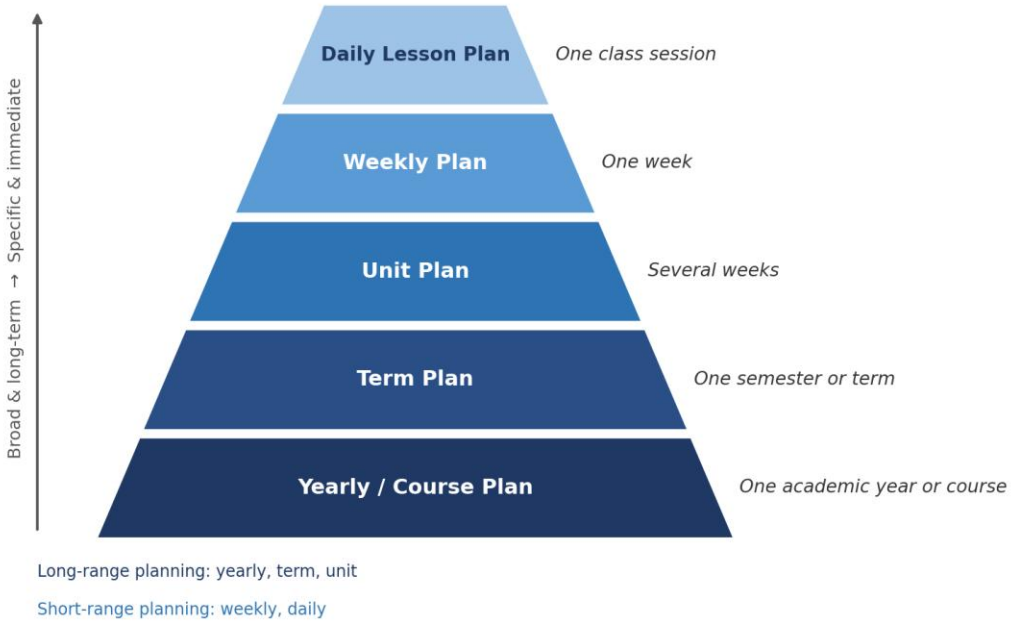


Figure 1. The Planning Pyramid: each level works within the boundaries of the broader level beneath it.

6. Types of Planning: Long-Range vs. Short-Range

	Long-Range Planning	Short-Range Planning
Levels covered	Yearly, term, and unit plans	Weekly and daily lesson plans
Main decisions	Curriculum mapping, pacing guides, and which standards are taught when	Specific activities, questions, materials, and time allocations for each class session
How often revised	A few times per term	Continuously, often daily, based on how earlier lessons went and what assessment evidence shows
Metaphor	Sets the map	Fills in the route

7. Resources for Planning

Effective planning draws on several sources of information rather than a single textbook:

- Official curriculum frameworks and the subject-specific standards in Section 4.
- Approved textbooks and their accompanying teacher's guides.
- Prior student assessment data, used to identify gaps or misconceptions to address.
- Colleagues and mentor teachers, through collaborative planning or lesson study.
- Professional and digital repositories of vetted lesson materials, simulations, and activities.
- Reflections from previous deliveries of the same lesson or unit.

Part C: The Daily Lesson Plan

8. Components of a Written Lesson Plan

While formats vary by institution, most lesson plans share a common set of components, each serving a distinct purpose (Borich, 2017).

Key Framework: Standard Lesson Plan Components

Component	Purpose
Objectives	State what students will be able to do by the end of the lesson (see Topic 2).
Materials / Resources	List everything needed to deliver the lesson (equipment, handouts, technology).
Opening / Set Induction	Capture attention and connect new content to prior knowledge.
Development / Procedures	Sequence the main teaching and learning activities step by step.
Guided / Independent Practice	Give students opportunities to apply the new content with decreasing support.
Assessment / Check for Understanding	Gather evidence that the objectives were met, during or at the end of the lesson.
Closure	Summarize key learning and preview what comes next.
Differentiation Notes	Describe adjustments for learners with different needs or readiness levels.

9. Planning for the Three Learning Domains

Lesson objectives can target one or more of three domains of learning. Each domain calls for different planning decisions (each domain and its taxonomy is examined in depth in a later topic).

Domain	Type of Learning	Planning Implications
Cognitive	Knowledge and intellectual skills (recalling, explaining, analyzing)	Plan explanations, examples, questioning, and problem-solving tasks.
Affective	Attitudes, values, and feelings (valuing, willingly participating)	Plan discussion, reflection, and opportunities for students to make and justify choices.
Psychomotor	Physical or manual skills (operating equipment, executing a technique)	Plan demonstration, enough hands-on practice time, materials for every student, and safety steps.

Applying This Topic Across the Four Specializations

The same planning structure looks different once it is filled with real subject content. For each specialization below, a subject standard is turned into a planning decision, followed by a sample unit, lesson, set induction, and planning resources.

IT

Planning Element	Example
Standard in action	ISTE Standards for Students – *Computational Thinker*. A lesson on a new programming topic does not start with syntax alone; students first break a real-world task (e.g., "plan the steps to make a cup of tea") into an ordered sequence of instructions before the matching code structure is introduced.
Unit / Lesson	Programming Fundamentals / Introduction to Conditional Statements
Set induction	Present a real-life if/then scenario ("If it rains, I bring an umbrella") and ask students to phrase two of their own before naming the coding structure.
Key resources	ISTE Standards documents; a simple flowchart template

Science

Planning Element	Example
Standard in action	NSES / NGSS – inquiry and science practices. Rather than only lecturing about photosynthesis, a teacher plans a plant-growth lesson around a testable question ("Does the amount of sunlight affect how tall a bean plant grows?") and has students propose a hypothesis and a simple experimental design.
Unit / Lesson	Ecosystems / Food Chains and Food Webs
Set induction	Give students cards naming local organisms and ask them to physically arrange a chain from producer to top predator.
Key resources	NSES/NGSS documents; local food-web diagrams

Mathematics

Planning Element	Example
Standard in action	NCTM Process Standard – *Problem Solving*. A teacher covering percentages opens with an authentic, under-specified problem ("Which of these three stores offers the best real discount?") and lets students choose their own strategy before formally naming the procedure.
Unit / Lesson	Linear Equations / Slope-Intercept Form
Set induction	Show a graph comparing the cost of two phone plans over time and ask which plan is cheaper after six months.
Key resources	NCTM standards document; graphing calculator or graphing app

Art & Design

Planning Element	Example
Standard in action	National Core Arts Standards – *Creating* (Anchor Standard 1: generate and conceptualize artistic ideas and work). A teacher planning a painting unit requires a page of thumbnail sketches before students touch paint, so each final piece reflects the student's own idea rather than a teacher-dictated design.
Unit / Lesson	Color Theory / Complementary Colors
Set induction	Display two paintings side by side, one using complementary colors and one not, and ask students which feels more vivid and why.
Key resources	National Core Arts Standards document; a physical color wheel

Summary

- Instructional planning turns broad goals into coherent, teachable sequences of content, activity, and assessment; it supports curriculum coverage, anticipation, differentiation, coherence, and accountability.
- InTASC groups its ten teaching standards into four categories: the Learner and Learning, Content, Instructional Practice, and Professional Responsibility.
- Each specialization has its own framework: ISTE (IT), NCTM (Mathematics), NSES/NGSS (Science), and the National Core Arts Standards (Art & Design).
- Planning happens at nested levels: yearly/course, term, unit, weekly, and daily. Long-range planning sets the map; short-range planning fills in the route.

- Good plans draw on several resources: standards, textbooks, assessment data, colleagues, repositories, and reflection.
- A written lesson plan includes objectives, materials, opening, development, practice, assessment, closure, and differentiation, and its activities should suit the domain (cognitive, affective, or psychomotor) being targeted.

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